Country Profile: Taiwan

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 4
- Plurality religion: Shenism
- Official language: None
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Mainland Chinese (1947–1991)

Historical Background

Throughout its history, Taiwan has been ruled by various powers. In the 17th century, parts of western Taiwan were briefly colonized by the Netherlands and Spain. The Qing Empire began its rule in 1683 but did not control the entire island, specifically the eastern regions inhabited by Indigenous peoples, until the late 19th century. After the First Sino-Japanese War, Taiwan became a Japanese colony in 1895. Following Japan' surrender in August 1945, the Republic of China (ROC), established in 1912, occupied Taiwan as part of the Allied forces. Unlike the temporary Allied occupation of Germany, Taiwan's occupation became permanent. In 1949, after being defeated by the Chinese Communist Party, the ROC moved its central government to Taiwan, where it has maintained control until today. The former Japanese Taiwan (1895–1945) now comprises 99.5% of the territory controlled by the Republic of China. Therefore, the name "Taiwan" is used here, although "Republic of China" is the formal name of the state responsible for Taiwan's nation-building policies since 1945.

The Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) and the All Minorities at Risk (AMAR) databases use 1949/1950 as the start year because Taiwan was a special province of the Republic of China between 1945 and 1948. However, the nation-building policies and political violence from that period still have a deep impact on identity and ethnic politics in Taiwan today; therefore, the NBP data uses 1945 as the start year in order to record the ethnic policies and events that occurred between 1945 and 1948. Following the conclusion of the Chinese Civil War, the Republic of China underwent a dramatic shift in its territorial boundaries, losing 99% of its territory in 1949. This event is recorded as a time of major border changes for the Republic of China in the NBP dataset.

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Groups

EPR and AMAR list three groups: Taiwanese, Mainland Chinese, and Indigenous Peoples (or Aboriginal Taiwanese). Indigenous peoples have been in Taiwan for thousands of years. Today, they mostly live in mountainous areas and eastern Taiwan. Mainland Chinese are immigrants from China after World War II and their offspring, while Taiwanese are the offspring of Chinese immigrants who arrived in Taiwan between the 17th and 19th centuries. According to the Minority Rights website, the Taiwanese are an umbrella group nesting Min-nan and Hakka people. However, Hakka people do not have significant markers of shared ethnic identity with Min-nan people; instead, they developed the distinct Hakka identity in the 20th century.[1] Furthermore, existing studies on ethnic politics in Taiwan consider Min-nan and Hakka as two distinct groups in their empirical analyses.[2] In sum, the NBP data lists four groups: Min-nan, Hakka, Mainland Chinese, and Indigenous Peoples.

- **Min-nan:** The Min-nan people, who migrated to Taiwan between the 17th and 19th centuries from what is now China's southern Fujian Province, constitute the largest ethnic group in Taiwan, comprising approximately 73% of the population.[3] Their culturally associated language is Min-nan Chinese, often referred to as Taiwanese within Taiwan.[4] In terms of religious affiliation, around 60% of the Min-nan people practice Shenism, also known as Chinese folk religion, while roughly 33% adhere to Buddhism.[5]
- **Hakka:** The Hakka people migrated to Taiwan between the 17th and 19th centuries from what is now China's Guangdong Province and currently comprise approximately 12% of the island's population.[6] The language of their common ancestry is Hakka Chinese.[7] Religiously, much like the Min-nan people, a majority of Hakka adhere to Shenism, or Chinese folk religion (71%), while a significant minority practice Buddhism (17%).[8]

[1] Chen, 2011.
[2] See Wang, 2008.
[3] Huang, 1993.
[4] Ethnologue, 2025.
[5] Joshua Project, 2025a.
[6] Huang, 1993.
[7] Ethnologue, 2025.
[8] Joshua Project, 2025b.

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- **Mainland Chinese**. Mainland Chinese, defined as post-World War II immigrants from China and their descendants, differ from the Min-nan and Hakka groups, originating from various provinces in China, including some ethnic minorities like Mongolian, Zhuang, Hui, and Manchu. Despite making up a small portion of Taiwan's population in 1945–1947, Mainland Chinese were politically important as they held many government and civil service positions. After fleeing the Chinese Civil War between 1948 and the 1950s, their population in Taiwan increased significantly from 0.5% in 1946 to 13–14%. Although the first generation spoke various dialects, they quickly adopted Mandarin Chinese as their lingua franca due to the national status of this language in China before World War II. They passed it on as the primary language to later generations. The EPR-ED notes that 69% of Mainland Chinese follow Shenism, and 24% are Buddhists. Politically, they were the core group in Taiwan from 1949 to 1991, controlling the executive, legislative, and judicial branches, with minimal inclusion of Min-nan, Hakka, and Indigenous elites.[9]

- **Indigenous Peoples** are small native Austronesian groups speaking Austronesian languages, comprising around 2% of the total population.[10] They are also called Taiwanese Aborigines and are considered a nested group of the three largest subgroups: **Amis** (ethnic population: 214,000), **Paiwan** (ethnic population: 103,000), and **Atayal** (ethnic population: 92,100).[11] According to Ethnologue, most Indigenous languages are not safe as of 2022, including the languages of the three largest subgroups: Amis (threatened), Paiwan (threatened), and Atayal (shifting). Indigenous Peoples' traditional religion is animism, and during the Japanese colonial period, they were forced to convert to Shintoism. After 1945, Christian missionary efforts among the Indigenous peoples of Taiwan were notably successful, leading to a significant portion of the population adopting Christianity. Today, most Indigenous peoples identify as Christians. However, many tribes integrate their traditional animist beliefs with their Christian faith, continuing to perform traditional ceremonies that honor the spiritual forces of nature. These ceremonies, which are central to their animist religion, are often embraced by the

[9] Vogt et al., 2015.
[10] Ethnologue, 2025.
[11] Ethnologue, 2025.

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Catholic church, creating a unique blend of Christianity within these communities.[12]

State Profile

Official Language

After 1945, Mandarin Chinese replaced Japanese as the national language in Taiwan. Min-nan, Hakka, and Indigenous languages were oppressed and discriminated against; some conservative legislators argued that it was unpatriotic to use "local languages".[13] In educational affairs, only Mandarin Chinese was used in schools, and history classes focused on the history of mainland China and neglected the history of Taiwan. This situation ended in 1987 when martial law was lifted; democratization forced the elites from Mainland Chinese, as a minority population group, to make political concessions to other groups.

The current ROC Constitution does not mention any language. The Development of National Languages Act, passed in 2019, declares that all "the natural languages and sign languages used by the different ethnic groups in Taiwan" are recognized as national languages.[14] However, Mandarin Chinese is the *de facto* official language, as it is still the only language of instruction in public schools and the major language used in public services and mass media.[15]

Official Religion

The ROC Constitution does not reference any specific religion, and no religion holds *de facto* official status.

Education Policies

In Taiwan, the national education system has three types of schools: elementary schools (grades 1–6; primary), junior high schools (grades 7–9; lower secondary)[16] and senior high schools (grades 10–12; upper secondary).[17] There is no ethnic segregation in the school system in Taiwan; it is common for students from different groups to go to the same

[12] Ministry of the Interior, 2024.
[13] Chen, 2009.
[14] Development of National Languages Act, 2019
[15] Leclerc, 2023.
[16] Primary and Junior High School Act, 2023.
[17] Senior High School Education Act, 2021.

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school and attend the same classes. The Primary and Junior High School Act and the Senior High School Education Act authorize private sectors to establish private schools, and the Private School Act[18] regulates the organizational structure of private schools.

Affirmative action policies are applied to Indigenous peoples. Since 1987, it has been stipulated that colleges/universities should lower the admission threshold for Indigenous students.[19] In addition, quotas for teacher recruitment are also reserved for Indigenous peoples per the Education Act for Indigenous Peoples, passed in 1998.[20]

Language Education Policies

After World War II, Mandarin Chinese replaced Japanese as the medium of instruction in both primary and secondary schools, and this policy still remains in force today. Other languages were not allowed in primary and secondary education until 1996, when "mother tongues" could be taught as part of the Local Culture subject in primary schools.[21] In 2001, the mother tongue class, which teaches Min-nan, Hakka, or Indigenous languages, became required in primary schools and optional in secondary schools.[22] In recent years, activists have advocated for making mother tongue classes in secondary schools mandatory instead of optional; however, as of 2020, the policy remains unchanged. This language education policy also extends to private schools.

Religious Education Policies

The NBP database records policies on five religions: Shenism, Buddhism, Protestantism, Roman Catholicism, and Other Christians. There is no religious education in primary and secondary education in Taiwan. Religious classes are not allowed in public or private schools. According to the 2021 Report on International Religious Freedom, religious groups in Taiwan are eligible to operate private schools, but authorities do not allow compulsory religious instruction in any accredited public or private elementary, middle, or high schools. The report also notes that high schools accredited by the ministry may offer elective courses in religious studies, provided these courses do not promote certain religious beliefs over others.[23]

[18] Private School Act, 2014.
[19] Ho, 2017.
[20] Education Act for Indigenous Peoples, 2021, Paragraph 1, Article 34; Paragraph 2; and Paragraph 5.
[21] Ministry of Education (Taiwan), 1993.
[22] Ministry of Education (Taiwan), 2000.
[23] US Department of State, 2021.

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Bans and Restrictions

Restrictions/Bans on Linguistic Practices

In 1953, Taiwan's provincial government banned the use of translators in cinemas who immediately translated movie lines into "local languages" (Min-nan, Hakka, and Indigenous languages). In 1956, the government further prohibited students from speaking local languages in schools.[24] In 1965, the provincial government enforced stricter language regulations, mandating that both students and employees use only Mandarin Chinese in schools, with students facing punishment for violations. Cinemas were also barred from using local languages, and local governments were instructed to encourage people to speak only Mandarin in public spaces.[25] In 1975, the government confiscated Bibles printed in local languages by the Presbyterian Church.[26] Between 1975 and 1986, the only legal context for speaking local languages in public was during electoral campaigns.[27]

Additionally, in 1963, the central government decreed that the use of Chinese "dialects" (Min-nan, Hakka, and Indigenous languages) in television and radio programs could not exceed 50%. The Radio and Television Act of 1976 further tightened these restrictions, requiring the proportion of dialects in broadcasts to decrease annually, a rule that remained in effect until its repeal in 1993. Before democratization, the names of Indigenous towns and villages were solely in Han Chinese; in 1989, the first town was renamed to reflect the wishes of the local Indigenous population. Moreover, Indigenous peoples were required to use Han Chinese surnames until 1995, when the Name Act was amended to allow them to reclaim their traditional names.[28]

Restrictions/Bans on Religious Practices

Shenism: Before democratization, the state implemented a series of policies to restrict religious publications and activities. In 1947, the Regulations for Prohibition of Bad Folk Customs[29] were made, in which Paragraphs 6 and 7 of Article 3 prohibited certain Shenist

[24] Chen, 2009.
[25] Ibid.
[26] Ibid.
[27] Ibid.
[28] Huang, 1993.
[29] "查禁民間不良習俗辦法".

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publications throughout the country. This regulation aimed to prevent "bad customs" from being learned in society.

Buddhism: the Orthodox School of Nichiren[30] was prohibited in Taiwan in 1963, including all activities and publications.[31]

Other Christians: In 1968, the government prohibited the publication of Jehovah's Witnesses' materials. From 1967 to 1986, followers of the New Testament Church were barred from entering their "holy mountain" in Kaohsiung, though they could still access other places of worship.[32] Although there is no specific documentation indicating when these restrictions were officially lifted, they were generally no longer enforced after political liberalization in 1987. Additionally, in 1975, the Presbyterian Church was prohibited from using Bibles printed in local languages.[33] However, this restriction relates to language policies rather than religious ones, as the state targeted the language of the Bible rather than its content.

Demographic Engineering and Violence

State-Based Violence

On February 28, 1947, ethnic tensions between the Taiwanese population and Mainland Chinese authorities, coupled with dissatisfaction over authoritarian rule, economic hardship, and government corruption, led to an eruption of protests. The immediate trigger was a conflict between police and local Taiwanese civilians, which quickly escalated into widespread political protests demanding reform. Mainland Chinese rulers, viewing these protests as a threat to their authority, responded by sending in the military to suppress the unrest. This brutal crackdown, known as the "February 28 Event," resulted in significant civilian casualties, with death toll estimates ranging from over 10,000 to 25,000.[34] However, the military's action was not only a political repression of protesters but also a systematic elimination of Taiwanese elites (this term referred to all groups on the Taiwan island except Mainland Chinese in 1947).[35] At the time, the government

[30] "日蓮教".

[31] Chang, 2009, 198.

[32] Ibid., 202–204; "新約教會"

[33] "新約教會", 210.

[34] Anderton and Brauer, 2016; Butcher et al., 2020.

[35] TMK Dataset, Appendix of Butcher et al., 2020.

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attributed this event to the Japanese colonial education that had been accepted by the Taiwanese before 1945.[36] Thus, the February 28 Event is considered political violence targeting Min-nan, Hakka, and Indigenous peoples.

Constitutions and Laws

Technically, there has been only one constitution enforced in Taiwan. The 1948 ROC Constitution, ratified in China, was quickly suspended due to the Chinese Civil War. It was designed to govern greater China. In 1991, this constitution was substantially amended to be fit for governing Taiwan. Since 1991, the 1948 Constitution has undergone several amendments. However, because these post-1991 amendments do not pertain to nation-building or ethnic politics, the NBP data recognizes only two constitutions: the original 1948 Constitution and the 1991 Amendment.

The 1948 Constitution makes no specific mention of any particular ethnic group. Article 5 states, "(t)here shall be complete equality among the various ethnic groups in the Republic of China," without identifying any specific group. Although the government referred to Mandarin Chinese as the "national language," the Constitution itself does not specify any particular official state language. Article 13 declares, "(t)he people shall have freedom of religious belief," emphasizing the principle of religious freedom without identifying any official religion. Furthermore, the Constitution does not explicitly mention secularism or the separation of church and state.

The formal title of the 1991 Amendment is "Additional Articles of the Constitution of the Republic of China." Article 2 of the Additional Articles reserves National Assembly seats for Indigenous peoples by explicitly mentioning "aborigines." This amendment does not alter Article 5 and Article 13 of the 1948 Constitution, which means it continues to omit any mention of state language, secularism, or the separation of church and state, while still upholding the universal recognition of religious freedoms.

Citizenship Laws

There is no group living in Taiwan whose members were denied access to national citizenship between 1945 and 2020. According to the Nationality Act, there is no birthright

[36] Chen, 2008.

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citizenship for people who were born in Taiwan to foreign parents between 1945 and 2020.[37]

National Anthem(s)

There has been one national anthem adopted in Taiwan since 1945. The anthem is officially available in Mandarin Chinese only. The lyrics refer to a political ideology, "Three people's principles, the foundation of our party," and include military references, "Oh, you, righteous men, for the people, be the vanguard." The anthem does not include references to nationhood or enemies.

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[37] Nationality Act, n.d., Article 2.

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